The Caribbean torpedo crisis

Many historians believe the encounter in the Sargasso Sea between the submarines of the Sixty-ninth Torpedo Submarine Brigade and US Anti-Submarine warships and aircraft led to the most dangerous moments of the Cuban missile crisis. This included the incident when Captain Valentin Savitsky, commander of the submarine B-59, prepared to fire his fifteen-kiloton yield torpedo at the US warships he believed were attacking his boat. History records that he was dissuaded from this course of action by Captain Vasili Arkhipov (the brigade chief of staff assigned to the B-59). Martin Sherwin argues that Captain Arkhipov saved 'the lives of thousands of U.S. sailors and millions of innocent civilians who would have been killed in the nuclear exchanges that certainly would have followed from the destruction B59's nuclear torpedo would have wreaked upon those U.S. Navy vessels.'[24] Arkhipov became 'the man who saved the world'.[25]

Knowledge of these events only began to emerge in the West forty years after the crisis. The US Navy's Submarine Surfacing and Identification procedures (described in chapter five) were made public in October 1962 and have been discussed in Western literature, notably Joseph Bouchard's *Command in Crisis*.ExComm's discussion of (or rather acquiescence in) the procedures, was revealed in May and Zelikow's *Kennedy Tapes* in 1997.[26] Nevertheless, Western historians had no inkling of the highly dramatic events in the Sargasso Sea (which Serhii Plokhy observes is home to 'the Bermuda Triangle'). These events suggest there was a risk that nuclear weapons might be used, and nuclear war break out. More importantly, neither US or Soviet political leaders (nor their senior military commanders) understood those risks.

Accounts of the Sixty-ninth Brigade's adventures began to appear in the Moscow press in 1995. By 2003 various books had been published, including in the West.[27] A critical oral history conference to mark the fortieth anniversary of the crisis was organised in Havana by the National Security Archive in Washington, Brown University, and the Cuban government. This provided opportunities to hear first-hand from those